

# THE ELECTION OF DONALD TRUMP

## Examining the 2016 Presidential Election

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The election of Donald Trump in 2016 was a significant political event for the United States due to Trump's unexpected win that reshaped political norms and party alignments. Trump's election can be best explained through the framework of right-wing populism and nationalism, both of which have affected American political culture. Right-wing populism is a political ideology that combines right-wing politics with populist rhetoric, emphasizing nativism and anti-globalization sentiments. Right-wing populism brings the people together into one pure nation; in order for the nation to be perceived as pure, right-wing populism typically has sentiments of anti-globalization and anti-immigration. Through this framework, Trump was able to win over many white working-class voters who believed that politicians from both parties had abandoned them. Donald Trump's election in 2016 was driven by right-wing populism and nationalism, which resonated with voters' economic grievances, cultural anxieties, and anti-elite sentiment.

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In the United States, the political culture has typically emphasized individualism, nationalism, and skepticism toward the upper class and political leaders. Economic individualism and self-reliance are important aspects of American identity, influencing citizens' views on economic policy and government involvement. As a result, economic hardships in the U.S. linked to globalization and the decline of industries are perceived as a personal betrayal of the American Dream. Trump recognized these sentiments and capitalized on them by presenting himself as a member of the working class, a man of the people, and someone who shared the classic American rags-to-riches story that resonated with many voters. Nationalism has also influenced American identity by creating resistance to globalization and immigration. Trump's campaign emphasized "America First," which played into the fears that foreign influences were threatening national sovereignty. Trump's anti-immigration stance appealed to the 62% of white working-class citizens who believed the growing number of immigrants was threatening American culture. One of Trump's

most controversial proposals was to build a wall along the U.S.-Mexico border, a concrete symbol of his anti-immigration campaign. 65% of Americans believe that political candidates run for office solely with the purpose “to serve their own personal interests.” This can lead citizens to feel their leaders are unbothered by the needs of ordinary citizens. Trump used this distrust as a way to connect with voters who felt their voices were ignored by the political class. Trump separated himself from political leaders by criticizing the Washington elites, which legitimized himself as the best candidate.

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Economic grievances were central to Trump’s appeal in the election. A core element of American political culture is the belief in individual success and upward mobility. However, due to the economic restructuring of the late 20th century and early 21st centuries --driven by globalization and automation-- there were many job losses, particularly for those working in the manufacturing and industrial sectors. The economic disenfranchisement is pronounced in the Rust Belt, where 28% of manufacturing jobs were lost. This led working-class Americans to feel abandoned by both Republican and Democratic leaders because they felt neither party was addressing their needs or concerns. Trump’s economic populism targeted these voters, presenting himself as a businessman capable of restoring lost jobs and economic prosperity. By positioning himself against economic elites and globalist policies, Trump tapped into the belief that hard work should lead to success, reinforcing the American ideal of self-reliance. This message resonated particularly among white voters without college degrees, who felt that traditional political leaders had failed them. Those without college degrees have fewer opportunities for upward mobility and, as a result, experience the economic decline --specifically the loss of manufacturing jobs-- more so than those with higher education and status, such as political leaders. These voters were more likely to view political leaders as disconnected from their struggles, given that many political leaders come from backgrounds of higher education and professional success. This perception intensified the appeal of Trump and his campaign.

In addition to economic grievances, cultural anxieties played a role in Trump’s election. American political culture has long been shaped by nationalism and cycles of nativism, particularly during periods of rapid demographic and social change. Trump’s nationalist rhetoric capitalized on these anxieties, portraying immigration and globalization as threats to American identity. In a study conducted by PRRI, “White working-class voters who say they often feel like a stranger in their own land and who believe the U.S. needs protecting against foreign influence were 3.5 times more likely to favor Trump than those who did not share these concerns.”

Trump's slogan, "Make America Great Again," evoked nostalgia for a past that many citizens believed was better. This appeal to traditional values was particularly effective among the white voters who felt their cultural and economic status was declining. Studies have shown that concerns over cultural displacement, rather than purely economic hardship, were strong predictors of Trump support. This highlights that economic factors were not the only reason for Trump's election.

Populism has been a recurring presence in American politics, challenging the established upper class and political leaders and advocating for the interests of the "common man." Trump's campaign embraced this tradition, positioning him as an outsider fighting against a corrupt political and media system. Trump's attacks on Washington elites, career politicians, and the mainstream media were central to his appeal to American citizens because he was able to separate himself from "political elites" and legitimize himself as the next presidential candidate. By framing the election as a battle between the people and a corrupt elite, Trump tapped into a long-standing distrust of centralized power. Many Americans were tired of feeling ignored by those in power, and Trump's campaign gave them a voice.

Donald Trump's election in 2016 is best explained through the framework of right-wing populism and nationalism, which influenced the American political culture. Trump's campaign addressed economic frustrations, cultural anxieties, and anti-elite sentiment, resonating with voters who felt neglected by other political leaders. His campaign's focus on individual success and economic issues made the "common man" see their struggle as betrayals of the American Dream, which increased and strengthened support for Trump's populist message. In addition, Trump's focus on nationalism and cultural identity concerns fueled anti-immigration and anti-globalization sentiments, reinforcing his "America First" messaging. Finally, the deep-rooted distrust of elites allowed Trump to position himself as a political outsider willing to challenge and fight against the elites. The persistence of right-wing populism and nationalism suggests that these tensions will likely remain central to future political movements and electoral outcomes in the U.S.

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